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▶ **To cite this version:**

Robert E Wray, Moritz Schmidt, Steven J Jones. Developer-on-the-Loop: Engineering Cognitive Systems with Coding Agents. 2026. ⟨hal-05691375v1⟩

HAL Id: hal-05691375

https://hal.science/hal-05691375v1

Preprint submitted on 13 Jul 2026 (v1), last revised 21 Sep 2026 (v2)

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Developer-on-the-Loop: Engineering Cognitive Systems with Coding Agents

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Abstract

Developing and maintaining cognitive-architecture-based agents remains labor-intensive and requires significant expertise, constraining both the scale of deployed systems and the breadth of cognitive-systems research. Research has shown that LLM-based coding agents can generate instances of knowledge encodings for cognitive systems. We build on this prior work to investigate if and to what scale coding agents can support the different stages undertaken during the creation of novel cognitive systems. We first introduce a framework that characterizes the cognitive-systems engineering lifecycle and then evaluate the use of coding agents across various phases of the lifecycle, presenting implemented case studies for Soar-based cognitive systems. Across case studies spanning specification, implementation, testing, debugging, refactoring, and architecture maintenance, effective use of coding agents required more explicit, *a priori* specification of requirements, representations, and design assumptions than is typical in cognitive-systems development; this process also surfaced implicit design commitments and supports improved maintainability. The human role thus shifted from hands-on implementation toward specification, supervision, and validation (“on the loop"), suggesting that the long-term contribution of coding agents may lie less in reducing implementation effort than in maturing cognitive-systems engineering practice itself.

1. Introduction

Cognitive systems researchers often emphasize designing, implementing, and refining integrated cognitive mechanisms and representations, or cognitive architectures (Kotseruba & Tsotsos, 2025; Langley et al., 2009). However, to demonstrate and to evaluate architectures, they must also create agents or applications in various domains (Newell, 1990). The development of such cognitive systems has historically required substantial knowledge engineering effort: encoding domain knowledge, constructing task-specific procedures, diagnosing failures, and maintaining complex

code bases.[1] Across architectures, this work generally remains labor-intensive and requires specialized expertise. As a result, the cost of developing and maintaining cognitive agents has often limited both the scale of deployed systems and the breadth of experimental investigations.

Recent advances in Large Language Models (LLMs), particularly models optimized for software development tasks, have led to significant disruption in traditional software development (Weisz et al., 2025; Panyam & Gujar, 2025). We use the term *coding agent* to capture the interactive assistants that use LLMs in the background, often embedded within integrated development environments (IDEs). Examples include Claude Code, GitHub CoPilot, OpenCode, Goose, etc. For traditional software engineering tasks, coding agents can generate source code, diagnose software defects, propose refactorings, and use external tools (e.g., commit code changes to a repository).

To what extent can coding agents support development of cognitive-architecture-based agents? Just as LLMs can contribute to the knowledge dynamically accessible to a cognitive agent (e.g., Nakos & Forbus, 2025; Kirk et al., 2024), we can also investigate their applicability in supporting various cognitive-systems development processes. At first glance, the application of coding agents to cognitive architectures may appear straightforward. The knowledge representations of cognitive architectures that support symbolic systems directly are ultimately expressed in programming languages or architecture-specific representations that should be amenable to code generation. However, cognitive-systems development differs from conventional software engineering in several important aspects. Developers must reason about symbolic representations and the underlying cognitive processes and architectural constraints. Further, the functional requirements for a cognitive system are often challenging to define completely or explicitly in advance. Consequently, it is not obvious which (if any) aspects of development can be delegated to coding agents and which continue to require substantial human expertise.

This paper examines the role of coding agents for cognitive agents implemented with Soar (Laird, 2012). To support this investigation, we developed tooling that enabled coding agents to execute Soar models, inspect outputs, diagnose failures, and iteratively revise agent implementations. We then explored the use of coding agents across a range of development activities, including production rule generation, operator implementation, debugging, testing, and refactoring. These activities provide an empirical basis for evaluating both the capabilities and limitations of coding-agent-assisted development within a cognitive architecture context.

Our findings suggest that coding agents may not only automate some aspects of agent knowledge encoding, but could help transform the development process itself. Researchers have recently concluded that similar transformation may be underway in software engineering more broadly (Hoda, 2026). Effective collaboration with coding agents required substantially more explicit specification of requirements, representations, and design assumptions than typical cognitive-systems research processes. However, the process of defining specifications often clarified unresolved design decisions and exposed implicit assumptions about agent behavior. Thus, coding agents may function not only as implementation assistants but also as a junior partner in knowledge engineering, shifting a developer's role from direct construction toward specification, supervision, and validation,

1. Increasingly, traditional knowledge engineering is complemented or supplemented by training processes, such as policy learning or explicit instruction. While these processes differ in detail from traditional knowledge engineering, they still usually require substantial human design and implementation efforts.

especially for domain-specific applications or agents (cognitive-systems engineering). The implications of this shift extend beyond the specific use cases and examples in this paper, suggesting new approaches to the development and maintenance of cognitive architecture-based systems.

2. Constructing Larger-Scale Cognitive Systems

Since the emergence of cognitive architectures, researchers have recognized that progress depends not only on advances in architectural mechanisms but also on the ability to construct, maintain, and evaluate increasingly complex cognitive systems (Newell, 1990). Importantly, as early architectures matured and began to be used as a foundation for applications (e.g., Jones et al., 1999; Gray et al., 1995; Corbett et al., 2001), some attention in the community shifted toward the engineering challenges associated with building larger-scale, more capable cognitive agents and testing them, often in challenging, simulation-based environments (Pew & Mavor, 1998; Laird, 2001; Schoelles & Gray, 2001; Gray, 2002; Gluck & Pew, 2005).

Methods and practices that can support the systematic development of cognitive systems, what might broadly be described as *cognitive-systems engineering*,[2] spans the development of methodologies, tools, and processes that improve the construction of cognitive agents, including knowledge acquisition, representation design, debugging, validation, and long-term maintenance. Cognitive-systems researchers have explored a variety of approaches, including software engineering methods for cognitive modeling (Salvucci, 2016, e.g.,), integrated specification and development environments (John et al., 2004; Koedinger et al., 2004), compilation from abstract or high-level languages (Crossman et al., 2004; Ritter et al., 2006; Salvucci & Lee, 2003; Jones et al., 2006; St. Amant et al., 2006), model tracing and debugging tools (Taylor et al., 2002, 2006; MacLellan et al., 2014), knowledge engineering methodologies (Schreiber et al., 2000), and reusable libraries of cognitive components (Taylor & Wray, 2004). For example, work associated with ACT-R has often emphasized methodologies for model development and evaluation, while Soar researchers developed tools for trace analysis, explanation, and agent debugging. While details differ, a key objective of cognitive-systems engineering broadly is to reduce the cost and difficulty of developing cognitive systems while improving their reliability and maintainability.

A recurring theme across this work is that cognitive-system capability is often constrained as much by engineering factors (expertise, time, cost, etc.) as by architectural limitations. The construction of cognitive agents often requires tedious manual effort to translate informal requirements into explicit representations, procedures, and knowledge structures. As systems grow in complexity, the burden of maintaining consistency among these artifacts can become a significant obstacle to further development and undercuts the ability to "cumulate" results over time, a key factor in the original conception of cognitive-architecture evaluation (Newell, 1990). The emergence of coding agents introduces a new possibility. Rather than merely providing better tools for human developers, coding agents may participate directly in the development process itself, generating, testing, debugging, and revising cognitive systems under human supervision. This raises the question addressed

2. We mean principals and tools that define an efficient and reproducible methodology for the development of cognitive systems, in contrast to Cognitive Systems Engineering (Hollnagel & Woods, 1983) in Human Factors.

in this paper: **do coding agents represent another incremental improvement in development tooling or offer more fundamental shift in the practice of engineering cognitive systems?**

A few recent efforts have explored direct integration of LLMs to assist in the generation of cognitive-agent code. They provide proof-of-concept demonstrations that motivate our approach. Wu et al. (2023) investigated the use of prompt engineering to support the generation of ACT-R and Soar model components, demonstrating that contemporary language models can produce architecture-specific artifacts with appropriate guidance. Similarly, Zhu & Simmons (2024) explored the generation of Soar productions from natural language task descriptions, providing evidence that language models can assist in translating procedural knowledge into executable rules. Wray et al. (2025) evaluate the use of a sequential series of LLM calls to construct and refine productions that implement a complete Soar problem space. These approaches use LLM code generation without a feedback loop. Yuan et al. (2025) combine Soar production generation with limited *in situ* testing of generated rules, moving closer to the (semi-)autonomous workflows we investigate.

In contrast to direct LLM generation, recent advances in LLMs have produced a class of systems commonly referred to as *coding agents*: software systems built around LLMs capable of generating software artifacts, interpreting source code, diagnosing failures, and interacting with external development tools. Unlike earlier code-generation systems, modern coding agents can operate within iterative development loops in which they document requirements, produce specifications, generate code, execute tests, observe failures, and revise their outputs in response to execution feedback. These capabilities have led to widespread adoption in software engineering tasks including implementation, debugging, refactoring, documentation, and test generation.

This work extends prior work in two ways. First, rather than focusing exclusively on using LLMs to encode knowledge, we examine a broader range of activities that arise during cognitive-systems engineering, including specification, design, debugging, and refactoring, using coding agents to support these tasks rather than LLMs alone. Second, we use coding agents integrated within IDEs, thus permitting coding agents to directly inspect, execute, diagnose, and revise cognitive systems under development. This broader perspective allows us to investigate not only whether coding agents can generate cognitive-systems artifacts, but how they may alter the overall process by which cognitive systems are engineered.

3. Potential Roles for Coding Agents in Cognitive-Systems Engineering

This section first introduces a framework that outlines the cognitive-systems engineering lifecycle, contrasting cognitive-systems development with traditional software engineering (SE) for each phase. We then consider the potential role of coding agents in supporting the cognitive-engineering process, again emphasizing the unique requirements imposed by cognitive systems.

3.1 Framework for Cognitive-Systems Engineering

Figure 1 summarizes a cognitive-systems-engineering lifecycle, identifying the span of activities in that lifecycle, including the somewhat parallel architecture R&D and cognitive-systems development processes. The architectural process involves investigating and refining the capabilities of a cognitive architecture. The cognitive-systems development process involves the creation of appli-

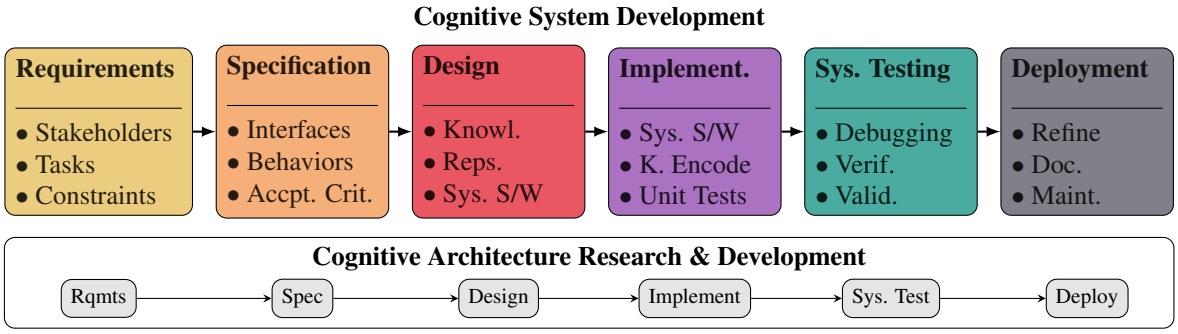


Figure 1: Cognitive-systems engineering activities, divided into cognitive-architecture R&D (bottom) and development of cognitive systems/applications (top). Tasks shown within boxes are representative, not exhaustive. Each stage is revisited many times during development (loops omitted).

cations or demonstrations of a cognitive agent in a particular domain. As this diagram suggests, one of the unique challenges of cognitive-systems development, in comparison to traditional software engineering, is that application development is dependent on the cognitive architecture, which itself may be changing. Practically, most cognitive-systems development occurs during periods when the architecture is largely stable.

Below, we outline these phases, focusing particularly on the development of cognitive systems (top process), which has greater commonality than architectural development across the cognitive-systems community. We contrast with SE where notable and illustrate with specific Soar examples. The phases are intended to suggest major classes of cognitive-systems engineering activities rather than to prescribe a sequential development process; in our experience, these steps are often iterative with many loops and jumps. Finally, we omit steps that are more relevant to research than the cognitive system itself, such as the creation of evaluation scenarios or data analysis.

Identify and Document System Requirements: Requirements analysis establishes the capabilities, constraints, performance objectives, and operating environments that the cognitive system must satisfy. Artifacts produced during this stage may include requirements documents, use cases, operational scenarios, domain analyses, and descriptions of relevant tasks and environments. While requirements elicitation is common to both cognitive-systems engineering and SE, cognitive systems often operate in open-ended domains where desired behaviors cannot be completely specified in advance and reasoning, adaptation, or decision quality criteria may be specified rather than functional outcomes. Methods such as cognitive task analysis (Militello & Hutton, 1998; Schraagen et al., 2000) are often used to elicit requirements from domain experts for cognitive systems.

Create System Specification: System specification translates requirements into a detailed description of the system to be constructed. Artifacts may include interface specifications, representation designs, procedural descriptions, knowledge models, behavioral expectations, and acceptance criteria. In contrast to SE, where specifications often focus on data structures, algorithms, and component interactions, cognitive-systems engineering must additionally specify the knowledge, reasoning processes, and behavioral competencies required to achieve intelligent behavior. Specific tools for coding agents (spec.io) have been developed to support specification in SE.

Design Cognitive System: During design, developers determine how the cognitive system will be organized to satisfy the system specification. As in SE, this step includes systems-software design such as defining system components, interfaces, middleware, and interactions with external systems. Cognitive-systems engineering additionally requires the design of the agent's knowledge organization and representations, including how information is encoded, structured, and manipulated by the underlying cognitive architecture. For example, for Soar agents, design typically spans working-memory organization, an initial problem space decomposition (operators, impasses, and default knowledge used for impasses), and commitments to specific knowledge representations.

Implementation: Developers construct software components and encode knowledge identified in system design. While SE focuses primarily on implementing algorithms and data structures, cognitive-systems engineering additionally requires knowledge engineering: encoding procedural, semantic, and other forms of knowledge in representations appropriate for the underlying cognitive architecture. In Soar, implementation involves coding productions, initializing semantic memory, and refining knowledge content and organization incrementally (in response to both ongoing development and agent learning). Unit tests are also developed during this stage. Unlike SE, where tests are often derived directly from detailed specifications, many subtleties of cognitive-systems behaviors often only emerge through iterative development, requiring concurrent test construction.

Systems Testing and Debugging: Testing evaluates whether the implemented cognitive system satisfies its functional and behavioral requirements. As in SE, this step includes integration and system-level testing to identify implementation defects and verify correct operation. However, because cognitive systems operate in complex, open-ended domains where detailed behavioral requirements are difficult to specify fully in advance, testing frequently reveals deficiencies not only in the implementation but also in the underlying knowledge representations, reasoning strategies, or even the original system specification. Consequently, testing and debugging often drive substantial revisions to earlier development artifacts, resulting both in comparatively more iteration loops and loops that "reach back" to much earlier stages in the development process.

Deployment: Cognitive-systems applications typically undergo continuing refinement as they are exposed to increasingly complex tasks and more realistic operational settings. This stage may include improving computational efficiency, refactoring knowledge structures, extending capabilities, enhancing learning capabilities, and updating documentation. While SE also includes deployment maintenance and optimization, refinement in cognitive-systems engineering frequently focuses on improving the agent's behavioral capabilities via refinement to reasoning and learning capabilities rather than simply correcting defects or adapting to changing requirements. As a result, "deployment" often results in a continuation of the iterative engineering process rather than a conclusion.

3.2 Expected Opportunities and Limitations

Table 1 summarizes hypotheses about potential role(s) of coding agents in supporting the cognitive-systems lifecycle. As noted in §2, there is already significant evidence for human-guided implementation support. We see opportunity to support other phases of development and also to automate many aspects of development, shifting developers to a more supervisory role (on the loop).

Where might we expect to observe the largest returns on investing in coding agent development? As outlined previously, the design-implement-test cycle in cognitive-systems development is highly

Step	Potential Role of Coding Agent
Requirements	Organize stakeholder inputs, generate draft requirements documents, identify ambiguities or inconsistencies, and maintain traceability.
Specification	Generate **detailed, structured specifications from informal descriptions**, identify under-specified aspects of design.
Design	Transform specifications into **detailed design artifacts**. Maintain consistency among evolving design artifacts.
Implementation	Generate code for both software components and **cognitive knowledge encoded in architecture-specific representations**. Generate/update unit tests as system evolves.
Sys. Testing	Generate behavioral & unit tests, **analyze execution traces**, ID inconsistencies between expected & observed behavior. Propose revisions to s/w or knowledge artifacts.
Deployment	Refactor software and knowledge artifacts, **improve run-time efficiency**, extend existing capabilities, update documentation, and assist with incorporating new functionality into deployed cognitive systems. Support **long-term maintenance of cognitive architecture** and update/maintain cognitive systems for latest architecture.

Table 1: Potential role for coding agents in the cognitive-systems-engineering lifecycle. **Bold text** identifies specific investigations reported in this paper.

iterative and time intensive. Thus, we focus primarily on these phases in our use cases. However, specification is necessary for good design. For instance, precise behavioral specification of agents might allow construction of initial unit tests that could then aid coding agents in detecting and fixing early bugs. Advanced integration tests might still require human supervision and inspection to ensure soft requirements are being met. In §5, we evaluate to what extent coding agents can support the items in **bold** in the table via implemented examples within a Soar development environment.

Finally, evaluation of cognitive architectures remains a significant methodological challenge (Langley et al., 2009; Laird et al., 2009). Newell (1990) envisioned that evidence for an architecture would be marshaled by cumulative demonstrations of results over time. However, in practice, little actual cumulation of results occurs in the cognitive systems community as the cost of updating, maintaining, and re-testing previously developed cognitive systems is prohibitive. However, the absence of cumulation of results and consistent theoretical commitments has resulted in skepticism about the falsifiability of cognitive architectures as a scientific enterprise (Cooper, 2007). Coding agents might provide substantial benefit to support cumulation, helping maintain, update, and evaluate prior cognitive-systems instantiations in newer versions, as an architecture continues to be researched and developed. While further investigation is outside the scope of this paper, we do include examples of coding-agent support for cognitive-architecture changes (both bug-fixes and minor changes). We expect that coding agents may not only facilitate maintenance but contribute to creating, documenting, and maintaining more explicit development rationales and history for architectures at the implementation/code level.

4. Customizing A Coding Agent for Cognitive-Systems Engineering

In this section, we outline the artifacts we created to support Soar-based cognitive-systems development. While many details are Soar-specific, this overall methodology applies to any cognitive-architecture-based cognitive-systems development. It consists of four primary components:

- *Project Goals and Development Philosophy:* This natural-language text file specifies high-level instructions to the coding agent. For these explorations, we use instructions that introduce Soar itself and the goal of the cognitive-systems development task.[3]
- *Skills:* Coding agents can dynamically load instructions for specific kinds of prescribed activities. We developed skills that describe how to format Soar rules, how to analyze Soar traces, etc. More details on specific skills are described in the use cases.
- *Subagents:* Coding agents can recursively invoke themselves to pursue a more tightly-scoped task. We discuss specific subagents for Soar debugging and profiling.
- *Soar-Coding-Model Interface:* A coding agent can only participate in the development loop to the extent that the development environment exposes actions it can take and feedback it can observe. For a Soar project, the coding agent must be able to edit a project's structure without corrupting it, know whether its edits are valid before running anything, and observe a running Soar kernel to diagnose behavior—none of which is available through plain text editing alone. To provide such functionality, we created a Soar Model Context Protocol (MCP) server, included in an open-source VS Code extension,[4] that gives coding agents structured, programmatic access to a Soar project throughout its lifecycle.

The coding agent we specialized for Soar bundles three complementary integration layers that, together, instantiate the development loop illustrated in Fig. 2: a Language Server Protocol (LSP) for syntax and on-save validation of Soar productions, an MCP server that exposes project structure and a live Soar kernel as agent-callable tools, and a debug adapter (Debug Adapter Protocol (DAP)) bridge to a running kernel. The coding agent alternates between editing artifacts, advancing only after passing deterministic verification gates (i.e., so-called"reflective components" in agentic LLMs; Legat et al., 2026), and inspecting runtime behavior to diagnose failures—each stage feeding the next prompt. Table 2 summarizes the three classes of tools exposed over MCP.

The MCP tools serve the two distinct runtime stages of the loop. In the *Unit Test* stage, the agent runs a fixed suite of integration or unit tests and obtains a deterministic pass/fail verdict, on par with the static verification gates above. The *Debug* stage is different in kind: the agent drives the kernel manually, advancing decision cycle by decision cycle and querying working memory, the matching of individual rules, and operator explanations as execution unfolds. Most diagnostic information is only available *in situ*; executing the kernel step-wise under the agent's control (non-deterministic)

3. These instructions are sometimes referred to `CLAUDE.md`, or `copilot-instructions.md` files, depending on the specific coding agent being used. Examples can be found in the repository linked below.
4. Available at: `https://github.com/tha-embedded-systems-lab/soar-code-extension`

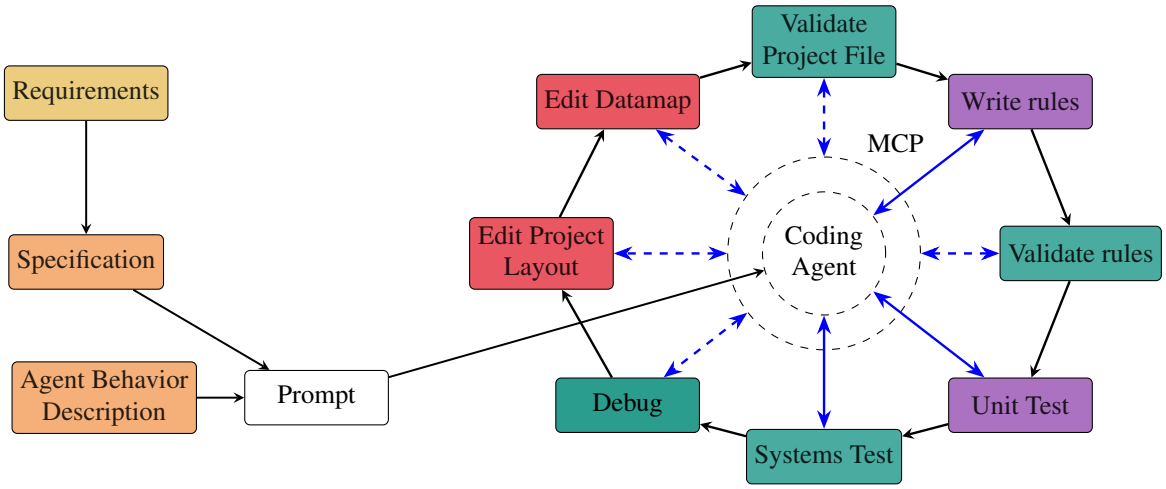


Figure 2: Example of a coding-model-supported cognitive-systems development lifecycle. This instantiation, with separate test and debug stages, is based on Schmidt (2026). Blue dashed arrows: coding agent primarily takes action via MCP, blue arrow: coding agent primarily takes direct action (e.g., file edit, CLI command). Box colors correspond to development activities illustrated in Fig. 1.

yields debugging information that post-hoc testing cannot. This exploration is interactive and interpretive rather than a fixed deterministic check; therefore it does not gate progress the way the test and verification stages do; it informs the agent's next round of edits.

Mediating operations through the MCP rather than direct file editing is essential for the project metadata. The datamap is a graph whose vertices and edges are referenced by internal identifiers; a coding agent editing the project file directly tends to introduce inconsistent, colliding, or unresolved IDs, which silently corrupt the project. The MCP layer instead uses tested functions, so that every structural edit yields a valid project. By contrast, productions are written as plaintext `.soar` files that the coding agent edits directly (the solid blue arrows in Fig. 2). The validation tools subsequently check these files for basic issues such as syntax errors.

The debug-adapter layer serves the human developer rather than the coding agent, and runs in parallel to the MCP runtime tools: both bridge to the same running kernel over its native Soar Markup Language (SML) interface, but the agent inspects execution through the MCP tools while DAP drives the developer-facing debugger. DAP is the same protocol VS Code's built-in debugger speaks to every supported language, so by translating between DAP and SML, the extension surfaces a running Soar agent through the editor's standard debugging facilities—breakpoints, call stack, stepping, and a variables/watch view—rather than a bespoke, architecture-specific debugger. This places Soar within the "default" developer experience, which matters precisely because the human remains on the loop: when the agent's autonomous test–debug iterations stall, the developer can inspect and steer the same kernel with the familiar affordances they use for mainstream languages, rather than context-switching into Soar-specific tooling. Lowering this barrier is itself part of the broader argument of this paper: much of the value of coding agents for cognitive systems

Tool	Description
Project-metadata Editing	*Edit Project Layout* and *Edit Datamap* stages manipulate a Soar project file, which encodes both the project structure (operators, files, and folders) and the *datamap*, a static representation of the structure of an agent's working memory. These tools add and remove project nodes and perform datamap CRUD (creating, updating, linking, and deleting typed attributes).
Verification & Validation	Enforce gating stages (*Validate project file*, *Validate rules*): they validate rules against the datamap, check the structural integrity of the datamap itself, which proves to increase the success rate of coding agents (Mathews & Nagappan, 2024).
Runtime	Connect to live Soar kernel and expose execution control (running and stepping decision cycles, pausing, setting the stop phase) together with inspection commands (printing working memory, productions, preferences, and operator explanations).

Table 2: Classes of tools provided by the Soar MCP server.

comes from making their development resemble ordinary software engineering closely enough that general-purpose tooling, for human and agent alike, applies.

5. Case Studies

We now describe several specific examples of how coding agents for Soar, outlined in the previous section, can be used to design, develop, debug, and refactor Soar agents.

5.1 Implementation from System Specification & Design

This use case summarizes the development of a cognitive agent to perform industrial robotics tasks, adopting a previously developed systems architecture (El Ghazi et al., 2024). The goal was to refactor this approach into an agent-based implementation grounded in a cognitive architecture via the Soar bridge to the Robot Operating System 2 (ROS 2)[5]. The system manages task-allocation negotiation through a set of autonomous agents, with each of the three robots controlled by an individual agent. All agents follow the same decision-making logic but differ in their physical characteristics, such as position, reach, and movement speed.

The agent design was structured around a set of problem spaces representing the task-allocation process: (i) idle, (ii) claiming an object for pickup, (iii) negotiating conflicting claims with other agents, and (iv) executing the assigned task. A detailed specification was developed iteratively, occupying the upstream stages of the development loop of Fig. 2: a requirements and specification document together with an agent-behavior description that frames each subsequent prompt. A coding agent was prompted encouraged to identify and highlight implicit assumptions, thereby contributing to the refinement and clarification of requirements. It also documented the specification as a Markdown document within the project workspace. The format and location of this document make it accessible to both human reviewers and the coding agent. Once the specification reached a satisfactory level of completeness as judged by human reviewers, it then served as a foundation for subsequent implementation, test generation, and behavioral analysis by the coding agent.

5. https://github.com/tha-embedded-systems-lab/soar_ros

Prompt	The Soar mastermind agent is in progress. This agent attempts to solve puzzles via a simple approach: it guesses randomly, and anytime it observes feedback with 0 black pegs, it marks those choices for those pegs as eliminated for future guesses. (This is not efficient, but it should generally work given sufficient turns). In some cases, the agent gets stuck and runs until an arbitrary exit criterion (150 decisions is met). Your goal is to identify the source of this specific "getting-stuck" error and attempt to repair it.
Debugging Transcript (Excerpt)	Both O181 and O182 are being REJECTED! Let me find what rule is firing the rejects:... *FOUND THE BUG!* Look at ‘preference*guess-peg*reject-duplicate‘: This rule rejects any ‘guess-peg‘ operator whose value already exists as a ‘guessed-value‘ on **any** peg in the current turn. ... Both 5 and 6 are already used as guessed-values on other positions (P45 and P44)! So ‘preference*guess-peg*reject-duplicate‘ correctly rejects BOTH operators. **The problem is that position 3 has ALL its non-eliminated values (5 and 6) already used in the guess!**

Table 3: Debugging prompt and Debugging subagent solution (excerpt) using Opus 4.5.

The problem-space decomposition was not encoded directly in production files. Instead, the coding agents implemented a partial design, in the form of the project structure, a layout of operators and files, and the corresponding datamap. It created the structure via the MCP tooling described in §4 (the *Edit Project Layout* and *Edit Datamap* stages of Fig. 2). Mediating these structural edits through MCP, rather than letting the coding agent write the project description directly to the file system, ensured that datamap consistency was maintained. It also gave the coding agent a specific, detailed model of working memory to reference when writing productions (that match against the structure of this memory). Thus, the design could be verified before any rule was sourced. Rather than attempting a single-shot implementation of the full specification, the developer instructed the coding agent to first construct a thin end-to-end integration slice—a minimal but complete path through the task-allocation process—and to increase functional complexity only incrementally thereafter. This strategy exercises the full loop of Figure 2 early and repeatedly. Representational or behavioral defects surface against working tests while the implementation is still small, rather than accumulating until a single large integration step. Consequently, the Soar agent emerged gradually, through multiple iterations of the loop, each adding capability and re-validating against the existing tests.

The Soar agent produced by this process (68 productions across 4 problem spaces) did not fully solve the problem once the coding agent (Sonnet 4.6) finished, but the deviations were localized and required only minor manual intervention in the form of additional tests and follow-up prompts including specification updates. Because the static verification gates described in §4—datamap validation and rule checks—supplied deterministic feedback at each turn, the iterations converged without substantial human steering: the generated implementation remained closely aligned with the intended design, and specification compliance was achieved with limited additional guidance.

5.2 Debugging a Cognitive Agent

Implemented cognitive systems are typically complex and often require human expert knowledge to debug. Here, we examine whether coding agents can autonomously perform debugging and compare debugging capability across different LLMs. As a test case, we prompted a coding agent to create a Soar agent that plays MasterMind via TextArena (Guertler et al., 2025).

We first created the Debugging subagent's own instructions and skills. Coding agents were used to generate initial drafts of the skills (e.g., referencing the Soar manual, executing Soar agents via

MCP, analyzing Soar logs), after which we manually iterated on these drafts, encoding our own Soar debugging know-how into the text instructions (some skills are supplemented with scripts). This refined subagent was then directed to resolve a specific bug using its instructions and skills (see detailed problem walkthrough below). We tested three LLMs in this role: Opus 4.5 (frontier at time of testing), Sonnet 4.5 (capable general-purpose), and Haiku 4.5 (limited size and context).

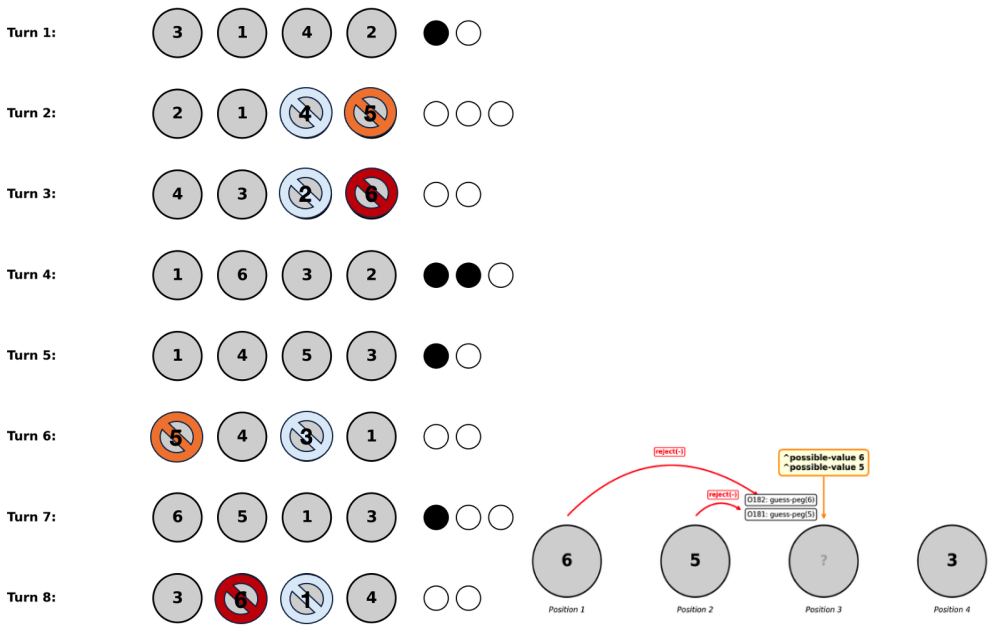


Figure 3: Conceptual illustration of MasterMind using Soar agent elimination of possible values (left) and the bug in the simple Soar agent (right).

In Mastermind, a player determines a sequence of four numbers drawn from the first six integers (in TextArena, duplicate values are disallowed). Fig. 3 shows a series of agent guesses. In response to each guess, TextArena provides feedback: a white circle indicates a correct value in an incorrect position, a black circle, a correct value in a correct position. The simple strategy the Soar agent uses is to eliminate position/value combinations anytime the feedback is all white. This strategy is not optimal[6] but it is sufficient to solve most puzzles within 20 turns (TextArena maximum).

Using this strategy, after Turn 2, e.g., the agent determines **5** cannot be in Pos. 4 and after Turn 6 that it cannot be in Pos. 1 (orange annotations). By Turn 8, elimination has narrowed values for Pos. 3 to **5** or **6** (light blue). In Turn 9, position 3 must be **5** or **6**, but both are already used elsewhere in the guess (Fig. 3, bottom), causing the agent to impasse. Table 3 shows the debugging prompt and the excerpt where Opus 4.5 identified the immediate cause. Among several proposed fixes (e.g., reversing an earlier peg choice), the agent chose to allow duplicate values in this situation. This

6. There is an optimal strategy for MasterMind (Knuth, 1977). We chose the strategy primarily to test instruction following for implementation and also because it would present various debugging and refactoring opportunities in a relatively simple-to-understand agent.

resolves the specific issue (impasse), but TextArena itself terminates games on duplicate guesses. This illustrates that the coding agent should perhaps be directed to identify alternatives for human review rather than resolve them autonomously.

Opus 4.5 resolved the issue (and several others); neither Sonnet 4.5 nor Haiku 4.5 succeeded, typically due to repeatedly retrying previously failed paths. Repetitive failure is likely due to their comparatively constrained context windows. While not conclusive, these observations suggest that coding agent capabilities are starting to near a point where they can support the full product lifecycle (and without specialized fine-tuning or context-management workarounds).

5.3 Refinement & Refactoring

We also explored the use of coding agents for refactoring. In one case, we created a Profiler subagent that focused on Soar-agent runtime efficiency. The Profiler was given instructions to ensure that the functionality of the Soar agent was not changed, but that it should look for classes of issues known to cause runtime inefficiencies in Soar. When the Profiler found clear inefficiencies, it invoked the Debugger subagent, posing those inefficiencies as problems for the Debugger to resolve. Using Opus 4.5, this combination was effective at identifying and resolving potential runtime issues. We deliberately created some specific issues for the system to "discover," and it found them (e.g., per puzzle, it reduced average runtime from .6s to .1s and eliminated over 2000 unneeded rule firings). Optimization refactoring is especially valuable for a coding agent because, for an experienced Soar developer, this task is typically tedious and time-consuming but conceptually straightforward.

Beyond efficiency improvements, refactoring can also aim to reduce logical complexity. The sanding robot agent described in Schmidt & Meitinger (2025) contained design structures that were more elaborate than required, introducing unnecessary complexity in terms of the length of production rules and the depth of working memory (nesting). Guided by integration-test outcomes, a coding agent successfully simplified the agent architecture, reducing 88 productions in the original to 78 after refactoring, while preserving agent functionality.

5.4 Architecture Development and Maintenance

While we have emphasized cognitive-systems development thus far, another workflow in the lifecycle is refining the foundational capabilities of a cognitive architecture itself. Architectural development demands strict adherence to core architectural principles to ensure long-term architectural stability. Further, architectures generally are highly unique instances of software, unlikely to be heavily represented within the training corpus of the model (unlike, for example, web development projects). Within this context, coding agents can both increase developer productivity but may introduce unique risks. In this section, we summarize recent experiences using coding agents to support various aspects of Soar development and maintenance, culminating in the release of Soar 9.6.5.

Platform Compatibility: A recurring challenge in community-supported architectures is balancing specialized architectural features with broad cross-system compatibility requirements. For instance, a community contributor proposed decoupling dependencies for Soar's Spatial Visual System from the core repository. A good suggestion, but implementing it required expertise for packaging new libraries for many different platforms. We used a coding agent to manage the multi-system

build integration for this change, effectively filling a breadth-of-knowledge gap for the developer. The agent generated the cross-platform boilerplate required, requiring only developer validation.

Architectural Bugs: Another task for the 9.6.5 release was resolving a complex use-after-free pointer bug deep within the core architecture. Resolving this defect required systemic knowledge of how multiple architectural components are integrated, ultimately requiring a minimal, single-line fix. However, the coding agent repeatedly proposed complex, generic patches framed as "defensive coding." In an SE context with distributed and interconnected services, code that silently catches pointer anomalies to preserve marginal and/or local functionality (and not propagate crashing) may be acceptable or even preferable. Within a cognitive architecture, however, such patches introduce silent failures that lead to non-deterministic behavior in downstream agent reasoning. For Soar (and likely other architectures), a "loud failure" is strictly preferred over a silent one. Coding agents cannot be naively deployed for intricate architectural defects without additional knowledge. For the future, we envision explicit coding-agent instructions that clarify development priorities for architecture code (e.g., "Fail loudly and early"). Generally, relying on coding agents for complex architectural modifications exposes significant risks regarding design philosophy.

Incomplete Features: In some cases, an apparent bug may actually be an intentional, incomplete feature. We received a community bug report about an apparent mistake in Soar's episodic memory implementation (EpMem), in which some data structures were not connected to the overall memory structure in the underlying database. In this case, attempting to use a coding agent for this apparent defect yielded no value. The agent attempted to implement an explicit cleanup mechanism to remove these "dangling" structures. However, the maintainers recognized that these dangling data structures were an intentional, albeit poorly documented, aspect of the episodic memory design intended for optimization and structure reuse. If the agent's fixes were reflexively accepted, it would have broken a core mechanism of the episodic memory subsystem. This example underscores that within cognitive architecture R&D, while coding agents may produce much of the code, review and conceptual validation require expert human judgment.

Managing Large Code Bases: Coding agents can reduce cognitive demand of unfamiliar components, supporting architectural consistency. The community wanted to extend Soar's parser, but its maintainers lacked deep expertise in the parser implementation. They leveraged a coding agent to analyze existing parsing structures and generate internal documentation. By synthesizing patterns from the existing code, the coding agent enabled the developer to implement a localized parser modification without investment to build expertise in an unfamiliar part of the architecture's code.

Legacy Code Maintenance: Coding agents can mitigate legacy technical debt. For example, some Soar graphical user interfaces (GUIs) rely on legacy Java frameworks. Rather than forcing a human developer to master antiquated standards until the GUIs could be updated, coding agents were deployed to perform basic maintenance patches and routine updates over twelve months. This approach extracted extended utility out of legacy infrastructure and required minimal human effort: the cost of the technical debt was absorbed by the coding agent. As another example, we used a coding agent to modernize the unmaintained VS Code LSP extension, as detailed in §4. Both examples illustrate how coding agents can effectively bridge gaps between historical code bases and contemporary software development environments.

Phase	Impact	Autonomy	Description & Justification
Rqmts	◑	○	Support elicitation, org., and refinement of requirements, improving specification quality for downstream development. Human judgment essential for system goals, priorities, and behavioral requirements, limiting agent autonomy.
Spec.	◕	○	Support creation of structured design specifications, interfaces, and behavioral descriptions that guide implementation; downstream benefits throughout lifecycle. Human input is critical to establish sys-arch. and ensure specs capture rqmts & intent.
Design	●	◑	Generate and refine detailed designs from well-defined specifications; good design enables greater automation of downstream implementation. Human oversight remains necessary to evaluate design alternatives and ensure architectural soundness, but details of common/familiar patterns can be automated.
Impl.	●	◕	Autonomously implement substantial portions of agent functionality and generate and execute accompanying unit tests from detailed designs. Less human intervention is required; human oversight focuses on validating correctness, architectural consistency, and behavior, not code development. Much faster dev. iteration.
Sys. Test	◑	◑	Automate testing, debugging, and repair workflows by iteratively executing, diagnosing, and revising agent behavior. Also, characterize specific issues for human resolution. May require frontier models. Human oversight essential for diagnosing complex behavioral and design issues and intervening when debugging goes off-track.
Deploy	◑	◔	Assist with refactoring, optimization, doc., & routine maintenance, improving code quality and maintainability. Human guidance necessary to ID priorities, eval. criteria, assess tradeoffs, and ensure continued alignment with system objectives.
Arch. Maint.	●	◑	Preserve arch. “knowledge" across releases. Support arch. evolution, modernization, and onboarding of new developers. Human guidance required for arch. direction and major design decisions, but coding agent can serve as institutional memory for long-term arch. development and reduce long-term maintenance effort and cost.

Anticipated impact/level of autonomy: ○:Low ◔:Low-Med ◑:Med ◕:Med-High ●:High

Table 4: Hypothesized impact and level of autonomy of coding agents for the lifecycle.

6. Discussion and Conclusions

We presented an overview of the cognitive-systems engineering lifecycle and several specific, implemented case studies of the use of coding agents to support the lifecycle. The coding agents did not require fine-tuning or specialized tooling other than the MCP interface to the cognitive architecture. Coding-agent instructions and skills employ natural-language instructions encoded in standard text files. These tools enabled cognitive-systems developers to leverage their existing expertise and knowledge to customize coding agent activities for cognitive-systems development and architecture maintenance and development with notably less direct time and effort.

Table 4 presents expectations for the long-term potential of coding agents in support of cognitive-systems engineering, drawing from the prior work we sketched and the specific case studies presented. For each phase of the lifecycle, we estimate the overall positive impact of coding agents on that stage of the lifecycle (left column) and the level of autonomy feasible with current/recent frontier models (right column). Greater impact indicates larger reduction in human effort (e.g., hours of development) across the entire lifecycle, not just within that phase. The fourth column briefly summarizes what the coding agents can do and justifications for impact and autonomy.

We anticipate the highest impacts on the lifecycle for cognitive-system design and implementation (e.g., encoding knowledge) and for ongoing architecture development and maintenance (as distinct from basic architecture R&D). For design and implementation, coding agents enable much faster development iterations (design-implement-test, as in Fig. 2) via a (comparatively) greater emphasis on explicit specification and design and substantial automation of many aspects of systems-level testing and debugging. While there is comparatively little automation potential from coding agents in the earlier phases, the anticipated impacts on design-implement-test depend on the documentation of well-defined requirements and specifications for a cognitive system. Coding agents can facilitate these earlier stages, but human input remains central to these processes.

These expectations portend faster advancement in cognitive systems but embed assumptions and limitations. First, as highlighted in the case studies, some of the advanced capabilities, such as autonomous debugging, require the most advanced frontier models, which may limit their practical impact due to accessibility and cost. Second, for basic research, where specifications and designs and patterns may need to be invented before an agent can be implemented, coding agents likely offer a more localized and modest impact. For future work, we will explore how and to what extent coding agents support research toward new cognitive-system capabilities. Finally, LLMs may offer alternative options for speeding and enhancing cognitive-systems research. For example, tools such as Paper2Agent (Miao et al., 2025), which creates custom MCPs from papers (and code repositories documenting the paper), might make it more feasible for researchers using one architecture to exploit research components developed by researchers using a different one, helping to bridge a recurring, bedeviling barrier to community-wide artifact sharing in cognitive systems.

Overall, we would encourage the use of coding agents to support cognitive-systems development. Our experiences, as outlined in the use cases, highlight the roles that coding agents can effectively inhabit today: performing implementation tasks, including knowledge encoding; automating basic unit and systems tests, with some evidence for limited but autonomous system debugging; and contributing to refactoring and consistency improvements while requiring little ongoing human direction. To enable these capabilities, we spent relatively more time than typical thinking through requirements, specification, and especially design than is our typical process. Thus, for cognitive-systems development using cognitive architectures and coding agents, the long-term significance of coding agents may lie less in reducing implementation effort and more in contributing to the maturation of the practice of cognitive-systems engineering itself.

Acknowledgements

This publication was created as part of the AI Production Network Augsburg research project funded by StMWK (H.6-M2126.5.2.2.1/1/1/1) at the Technical University of Applied Sciences Augsburg. We thank staff of the Center for Integrated Cognition and members of the Soar Community for feedback and suggestions on what is required and desired for customizing coding agents.

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